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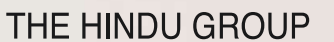
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The Hindu Year Book 2026

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BJP will fail to make any electoral gains in Kerala: Pinarayi

S. Anandan
KANNUR

Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan says recent defections by several Left Democratic Front leaders to the Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to contest the State Assembly election demonstrate betrayal and an erosion of values on their part. They will be powerless to ruffle the Left's electoral fortunes, he adds.

In an interview on Saturday with *The Hindu*, the Chief Minister spoke about why he considered the Congress a B-team of the BJP and why the BJP would fail to make any electoral gains in the State this time as well.

Mr. Vijayan said set-backs to the Left Front in some places in the local body elections could not be construed as a prevalent anti-incumbency sentiment against the State government.

The Left, he said, has maintained a good relationship with all communities, ruling out consolidation of community votes against the ruling front.

He said the government had strived to bring Kerala in step with modern times, and the people would recognise the effort.

The Kerala Chief Minister called the BJP's "develop Kerala" slogan duplicitous, citing the Centre's "callous" attitude towards the State in the face of adversities.

INTERVIEW ON
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Will completely close Hormuz Strait: Iran after Trump's threat

U.S. President had threatened to 'obliterate' Iran's power plants if Tehran did not fully reopen the Strait within 48 hours; hitting back, Iran's Parliament Speaker says critical infrastructure in West Asia could be 'irreversibly destroyed' if attacked

Reuters
Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON/TEHRAN

The Iranian military on Sunday threatened to completely shut down the strategic Strait of Hormuz and attack U.S. infrastructure, including energy facilities in the Gulf, if U.S. President Donald Trump acts on threats to target the country's power plants.

Mr. Trump on Saturday threatened to "obliterate" Iran's power plants if Tehran did not fully reopen the Strait of Hormuz within 48 hours, suggesting a significant escalation barely a day after he talked about "winding down" the war, now in its fourth week.

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said that the U.S. may need to "esca-



Assessing damage: People inspecting the site of an Iranian missile strike in Dimona, Israel on Sunday. AFP

late" its attacks against Iran to be able to wind down the war. Asked if Mr. Trump was winding down or escalating the war, he said: "They're not mutually exclusive. Sometimes you have to escalate to de-escalate."

The strait has been ef-

fectively closed since the start of the war, sparked by U.S.-Israeli bombardment of Iran. The conflict has since spread across West Asia, with Iran responding with attacks on Israel and U.S. interests in the region.

"If the U.S.'s threats regarding Iran's power plants

PM chairs meet to review impact of conflict on India

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

As tensions continue to mount in West Asia, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday chaired a meeting of the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) to review the

situation and suggest mitigating measures. A government statement said that the conflict's impact over the short, long and medium term were assessed.

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libaf wrote on X that critical infrastructure in West Asia could be "irreversibly destroyed" should Iranian power plants be attacked.

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NEARBY



RDSO to soon inspect Pink Line elevated stretch

BENGALURU
The Research Designs and Standards Organisation (RDSO) is set to commence a series of crucial inspections on the elevated stretch of Bengaluru's Namma Metro Pink Line.

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Quota: Religious heads leading campaign

BENGALURU
As the government tries to address challenges in the reservation matrix, communities — led by their religious heads — will be flexing their strength.

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EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 15

CPI(M) seeks time to discuss Stalin's offer of five seats

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

On a day when Tamizhaga Vazhuvirimai Katchi leader T. Velmurugan exited the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam-led alliance in Tamil Nadu, the Communist Party of India (Marxist) left a small window of opportunity open on Sunday afternoon, saying it would revisit the DMK's offer of only five seats for the April 23 Assembly election.

CPI(M) State secretary P. Shanmugam told presspersons here that party leaders had met DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin to explain its State Committee's decision to contest six seats.

"But the Chief Minister has asked us to accept five seats, as new parties have joined the alliance. We will again discuss the Chief Minister's suggestion in our State Secretariat meeting and convey our decision to him," Mr. Shanmugam said after meeting Mr. Stalin.

Meeting likely soon
The CPI(M) Secretariat meeting was likely to be held on Sunday evening or Monday.

He said the State Committee and Secretariat meetings held on Saturday had decided there was no



P. Shanmugam

need to increase the stakes beyond six seats. The party's general secretary, M.A. Baby, attended the meeting.

Mr. Shanmugam said the Chief Minister had explained to the CPI(M) seat-sharing committee the difficulties in parting with more seats.

"The CPI(M) would like to continue in the DMK alliance. But, the Chief Minister has asked us to settle for five. However, the mandate of the CPI(M) State Committee is for six seats. We have told him we cannot come to a conclusion immediately. The Chief Minister wants us to take a favourable decision," he said.

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Assam police camp attacked by ULFA(I), four injured

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Four Assam police commandos were injured in an extremist attack in Tinsukia district of eastern Assam on Sunday morning.

District officials said the assailants fired indiscriminately and lobbed several grenades at the commando camp at Jagun, close to the boundary with Arunachal Pradesh.

The commandos retaliated and the gunfight continued for about 30 minutes before the attackers slipped away.

The United Liberation Front of Assam (Independent) claimed responsibility for the attack.

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Bypolls: Cong. gives ticket to Umesh Meti and Samarth Mallikarjun

The Hindu Bureau
BELAGAVI/BENGALURU

Amid several claimants and fierce competition among family members, the Congress on Sunday announced Umesh Meti and Samarth Mallikarjun as its nominees for the Bagalkot and Davangere South Assembly constituencies respectively, which are going to the polls on April 9. Already, Congress is staring at trouble from a rebel candidate in the fray in Davangere South.

The byelections to Bagalkot and Davangere South have been necessitated following the death



KPCC president D.K. Shivakumar handing over the 'B' form to Minister S.S. Mallikarjun whose son, Samarth Mallikarjun, is the party candidate for the Davangere South Assembly bypoll, in Bengaluru on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

of Congress leaders H.Y. Meti and Shamanur Shivashankarappa respectively. Mr. Umesh is the young

son of the late Meti and Mr. Samarth is the son of Mines Minister S.S. Mallikarjun and grandson of the late Shamanur Shivashankarappa.

Nomination papers
Chief Minister Siddaramaiah and Deputy Chief Minister and KPCC president D.K. Shivakumar are scheduled to be present when the two candidates file their nomination papers on Monday — the last date for of filing of papers. The counting will take place on May 4.

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M BG-BGE

RDSO to soon begin inspections of elevated stretch of Pink Line

A comprehensive evaluation of the 7.5-km elevated section between Kalena Agrahara and Tavarekere will be conducted

Darshan Devaiah B.P.
BENGALURU

The Research Designs and Standards Organisation (RDSO) is set to commence a series of crucial inspections on the elevated stretch of Bengaluru’s Namma Metro Pink Line, as the Bangalore Metro Rail Corporation Limited (BMRL) prepares to open the corridor by May 2026. According to officials, the inspection process is likely to begin by the end of March and continue until the first week of April. The RDSO team will conduct a comprehensive evaluation of the 7.5-km elevated section between Kalena Agrahara and Tavarekere. The trials will include train speed and load tests, track and alignment assessments, station infrastructure checks, and verification of power supply systems.

A senior BMRL official said the inspection marks a



After multiple deadline extensions, the Pink Line is entering its final phase of readiness. K. MURALI KUMAR

critical milestone in the commissioning process. “The RDSO inspection is a mandatory safety and performance validation step before opening any metro corridor for public operations. We are confident the elevated stretch is well-prepared, as all civil works have been completed and system integration tests are progressing as planned. The trials will help ensure

the corridor meets the highest safety and operational standards,” the official said. After multiple deadline extensions, the Pink Line is entering its final phase of readiness. As part of the rolling stock supply, Bharat Earth Movers Limited (BEML) has been contracted to deliver 318 standard-gauge metro cars for the Pink and Blue Lines. These

trainsets are being designed, engineered, and manufactured at BEML’s Bengaluru facility under a ₹3,000-crore agreement, which also includes maintenance support for up to 15 years. The trains are equipped with communication-based train control (CBTC) technology, enabling fully driverless operations once the system becomes fully functional.

While the majority of the 21.3-km Pink Line runs underground, only the elevated stretch is expected to be opened in the first phase. The remaining 13-km underground section between Dairy Circle and Nagawara is targeted for completion by the end of 2026.

Meanwhile, BMRL has begun preparatory works along the elevated corridor. Name boards have been installed at stations, and a beautification drive has been launched along Bannerghatta Road. Authorities are clearing garbage accumulated beneath metro pillars and viaducts, installing barricades to prevent further dumping, and planting saplings to enhance the corridor’s aesthetics. The Pink Line, a key stretch of Phase 2 of Namma Metro, will eventually connect Kalena Agrahara in the south to Nagawara in the north, creating a vital north-south metro corridor in the city.

GBA electoral rolls: Deadline to file objections is now March 30

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

The State Election Commission has extended the deadline for filing claims and objections to the ward-wise revised draft electoral rolls for the five city corporations under the Greater Bengaluru Authority (GBA) to March 30.

This is the second time the commission has extended the deadline, extending the overall objection period from 11 days to 21 days. Earlier, the final electoral roll was scheduled to be published on April 6. With the second deadline extension, there will be a 12-day delay in the overall timeline, officials said.

They told *The Hindu* that the decision was taken amid pressure from recognised political parties, which pointed to a six-day

This is the second time the deadline has been extended

disruption of the voter verification website from March 13 due to technical issues. They also noted that draft rolls were made available to political parties only on March 16, leaving limited time for scrutiny. With festival holidays leading to travel, parties argued that a verification process was not possible within the earlier deadline.

There were also requests from the resident welfare associations and public, who cited difficulties in verifying voter details through the EPIC and name search facilities and sought additional time to scrutinise the rolls.

According to the revised schedule, corrections to the electoral rolls will now

be carried out between March 31 and April 1, followed by quality checks from April 2 to April 4. The final electoral rolls will be generated between April 5 and April 9, printed from April 10 to April 17, and published on April 18.

The extension, a GBA official said, will affect the electoral roll revision process by pushing back subsequent stages including data correction, quality checks, and final roll generation. “Since the final electoral roll is the statutory basis for all poll-related activities, including voter eligibility, polling station mapping and preparation of voter slips, any delay in its publication reduces the administrative buffer available for these processes,” the official said, adding that the main aim is to ensure accuracy and inclusiveness of the rolls.

Three killed as mini-truck rams stationary vehicle

The Hindu Bureau

Three men were killed in a road mishap after their mini-truck crashed into a stationary truck near Meda-

halli in east Bengaluru on Saturday night. The deceased have been identified as Suresh, Manikanta, and Srinivas, residents of east Bengaluru. The trio were arriving in the city

from Hoskote when the incident occurred. According to the police, a small truck was stationed near the Medahalli flyover after its tyre got punctured at around 11.30 p.m. The driv-

er of the mini-truck failed to notice the stationary vehicle and rammed it from behind. “The impact left two people in the truck dead, while one was severely injured. He too suc-

cumbed to his injuries,” the police said. A preliminary probe suggests that the stationary truck driver failed to take all necessary precautionary measures, which led to the crash.

Lamborghini stunt: Notice served on Muthappa Rai’s son Ricky Rai

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Bengaluru City Police have summoned Ricky Rai, son of former underworld operative Muthappa Rai, in connection with a case involving a Lamborghini car performing dangerous stunts at Anil Kumble circle in the heart of the city on Saturday, putting the lives of the public at risk.

A white Lamborghini was seen in a video doing donuts at the junction before speeding away towards Tonique Circle. The car then took a U-turn and sped away towards Trinity



The car which was captured performing stunts at the Anil Kumble circle. ALLEN EGENUSE J.

Junction. A senior police officer overseeing the case told *The Hindu* that the high-end car was traced to Mr. Rai’s residence in Sadashivanagar. The Cubbon Park Traffic Police seized the vehicle and towed it to the station.

“The registration number isn’t linked to the owner’s details, and there is no clarity on who owns the vehicle, although we found it at Mr. Rai’s residence. We served him two notices – one in the morning and another in the evening – asking him to appear for questioning on Sunday,” the officer told *The Hindu*. But he did not appear before the police. “We will serve one more notice on Monday, and if he still fails to appear, we will move the court for further procedure,” he added.

As there is no clarity on the car’s ownership, the

police have written to the RTO seeking more information on the vehicle registration. The police are yet to ascertain whether the car was driven by Mr. Rai or if he is merely connected to the driver. The luxury sports car, performing drifting stunts at the junction, was filmed by a citizen. As the post went viral, the police took up a *suo motu* case. They reviewed footage from more than 50 CCTV cameras across the city to track the car and trace it to Mr. Rai’s residence. The Cubbon Park Traffic Police seized the car in less than a day.

City’s iconic single-screen Urvashi reopens; fans heave a sigh of relief

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

In a surprising turn of events, Urvashi Cinema, one of Bengaluru’s iconic single screens, has reopened, with the much-talked-about *Dhurandhar: The Revenge* running to a full house in the theatre. After the expiry of the 45-year lease, it seemed like curtains would come down on the king-size theatre, but for now, it’s good news for fans. The Kannada rural drama *Landlord*, starring Duniya Vijay, was the last film screened in January 2026 before the theatre shut down operations following a court order. The High Court of Karnataka had directed the tenants to hand over the vacant land, by demolishing the existing buildings, to the landlords by February 15.

There has been no offi-



According to reports, the owners of Urvashi Cinema have received a three-year extension of the lease. ALLEN EGENUSE J.

cial word on the latest development, but according to reports, the theatre owners have received a three-year extension of the lease. Regular patrons of Urvashi Cinema took to social media to express their relief. “We watched *Dhurandhar 2* at Urvashi. We enquired at the ticket counter about the news of the theatre’s closure, and they said ‘Urvashi isn’t go-

ing anywhere,’” said a fan on Reddit. Fans on X wished theatre owners would consider a renovation to stay more relevant in the multiplex era.

While it remains to be seen if Urvashi is back for a long run, the theatre’s second innings has got off to a flying start, with tickets for the sequel of *Dhurandhar* getting sold out in quick fashion.



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M BG-BGE

A photograph of a bird, likely a heron or egret, standing on a rocky shore. The bird has long legs, a long neck, and a long beak. It is facing right. The ground is composed of light-colored, irregular rocks. In the background, there is a body of water reflecting the sky and surrounding vegetation. The water is calm, and the reflection is clear. The overall scene is a natural, outdoor setting.

M RG-RGE



Harvesting anxiety

Assam goes to the polls amidst another political churn

The BJP is seeking a third consecutive term in Assam in Assembly polls on April 9, while the Congress is fighting to make a comeback after 10 years in the wilderness. In 2021, the coalition of BJP, AGP and UPPL won 75 of 126 seats, with the BJP alone winning 60. Communal mobilisation and welfare schemes make the standard BJP toolkit here too, but Assam is a unique theatre of political experimentation for the party and its governments at the State and the Centre. Conflicts over large-scale migration of Bengali-speaking people have long shaped Assam’s politics. Nativist politics developed primarily in opposition to this migration. The BJP’s growth has come by recasting that nativism into a question of Hindu-Muslim conflict, creating a new political dynamic weakening subnational outfits and pressuring the Congress. The Citizenship (Amendment) Act 2019 enacted a communal eligibility clause for people who entered India from Bangladesh. Nativist opposition to citizenship for any immigrant – including Hindus – and other factors stalled the large-scale rollout of the law, but rhetoric over demographic change remains the mainstay of politics. This will be the first Assembly poll after the 2023 delimitation of constituencies, which has displayed patterns of communal gerrymandering, reducing the impact of Muslim voters and enhancing representation for indigenous communities. BJP functionaries, including Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, have been open about the intended impact.

Meanwhile, the BJP continues to recruit leaders from the Congress. The AIUDF, mainly representing Bengali-speaking Muslims in lower Assam and the Barak Valley, contributed to the collapse of the Congress in 2016, now fights for survival, contesting alone after exclusion from the Congress-led Opposition alliance. The Congress has allied with the Rajior Dal, led by activist Akhil Gogoi, and the AJP, a party born from the anti-CAA movement that channels renewed Assamese sub-nationalism among younger voters. Their common ground is the promise of democratic governance, land rights, and inclusive development. The AGP, once the torch-bearer of Assamese regionalism, is a junior NDA partner contesting 26 seats, its independent ideological space largely absorbed by its larger ally. In Bodoland, the BJP has replaced its 2021 partner, the UPPL, with the BPF, an older formation. In 2021, the BJP had managed to subsume most regional sentiment through alliances and the recasting of the migration debate. Big infrastructure projects are presented as milestones, but allegations of crony capitalism and disregard for the environment are serious. Such substantive questions get sidelined as fear rather than hope dominates.

Digital exile

The government could be creating a system of arbitrary censorship

A decade-long trend in digital governance in India crescendoed last week when a slew of social media accounts operated by independent activists and journalists were blocked apparently for criticising the Union government and Prime Minister Narendra Modi over his government’s West Asia policies and the LPG crisis. In seven years, from 2014 to 2021, the number of URLs, posts, and accounts blocked ballooned from 470 to 9,800; since then, there is evidence that entire accounts, especially if they were publishing politically unfavourable comments, were being blocked. There was a wave of censorship during the farmers’ protest in 2020-21; the government restored many accounts after international outcry but this also demonstrated that it was not beyond mass censorship. Similarly, the government used emergency powers under the IT Rules to block links to a BBC documentary in 2023, which also expanded the definition of what constituted a “threat to public order”. But when Twitter (now X) challenged several blocking orders, between 2021 and 2022, in the Karnataka High Court, the High Court dismissed the plea and fined Twitter, further emboldening the state to censor accounts.

In *Shreya Singhal* (2015), the Supreme Court of India upheld Section 69A of the IT Act 2000 precisely because of its procedural safeguards, including requiring reasoned orders and judicial review. In practice, however, the government has been diluting the safeguards through an expansive use of Rule 16 of the 2009 Blocking Rules, which requires blocking proceedings to be confidential. When this stipulation is invoked to withhold blocking orders or their reasons from affected parties, it undermines their ability to challenge the action in court, eroding the very safeguards that justified the constitutionality of Section 69A. The 2009 Rules also require blocking orders to be reviewed by a committee composed under the IT Rules 2009, yet this is an entirely executive body and has never overturned a government blocking order. In effect, the government is openly and systematically bypassing the right to be heard and violating the doctrine of proportionality. Rule 16 is a procedural rule, yet the government is using it to override the constitutional right to free speech while shielding itself from judicial review. A person’s entire account being blocked amounts to a digital exile, removing the person from the public square, which is a hallmark of an authoritarian government rather than of a liberal democracy. The government’s plan to decentralise blocking powers to multiple Ministries could effectively create a regime of arbitrary censorship, where any department can silence a critic without the specialised oversight, however flawed, of the IT Ministry.

‘Double engine’ — cute slogan, a serious federal question

Every election season produces memorable slogans. Most fade once the votes are counted, but some linger and begin to shape how citizens think about governance itself. One such phrase is the “double-engine *sarkar*”. At first hearing, it sounds harmless, even cute: two governments working in tandem to accelerate development. Yet, behind the metaphor lies a serious constitutional question about India’s federal compact.

The idea is simple: if the same party governs both the Union and the State, development will move faster because the two governments will work in harmony. Taken at face value, this is unexceptionable. Of course governments at different levels should coordinate. That is indeed cooperative federalism. The real question is what happens when they do not share the same political ideology. But the “double-engine” slogan carries a deeper implication. It suggests that development flows preferentially to States governed by the same party as the Union government.

‘Aligned States’ benefit

During election campaigns the message is often made quite explicit: elect the party ruling at the Centre so that your State can benefit from faster development. If you do not, you will be starved of funds. This is where the constitutional difficulty begins.

India’s Constitution does not envisage a system where State governments depend on the goodwill, or charity, of the ruling party at the Centre. It creates a federal structure in which the Union and the States are partners within their respective spheres. The Union government represents the Republic as a whole, not merely those States governed by the party in power in New Delhi.

Public money collected through national taxation belongs to the Union of India, not to the ruling party. Taxes are collected in the name of the Republic, from citizens of every State regardless of how they vote. The distribution of these resources cannot depend on which party governs a State. A citizen in Kerala or Tamil Nadu pays the same taxes as a citizen in Uttar Pradesh or Madhya Pradesh. The constitutional promise is that both will receive their fair share in return.

India’s constitutional framers understood this danger. That is why they built institutional safeguards into the system. The most important is the Finance Commission. Under Article 280, the Finance Commission is appointed every five years to recommend how Union revenues should be shared with the States. Its purpose is vital: fiscal transfers must be rule-based, not politically negotiated. The Commission evaluates States on objective criteria – how far their incomes lag



S.Y. Quraishi

is a former Chief Election Commissioner of India

behind the national average, their population, geographic size, and fiscal capacity – so that politics cannot determine who gets what.

Issues raised by States, federal friction

Recent debates around fiscal federalism show how sensitive this issue remains. Southern States have expressed concern that the use of more recent population data in allocation formulas may penalise them for having successfully controlled population growth. Another issue is the increasing resort of the Union government to cesses and surcharges, which fall outside the divisible pool and are not shared with States. This effectively reduces the quantum of resources available for constitutionally mandated sharing, concentrating more fiscal power in Union hands and weakening the financial autonomy of States. The Sixteenth Finance Commission, which is currently deliberating, will have to grapple seriously with these concerns if it is to restore confidence in the fairness of the fiscal federal arrangement

Governments in Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana have argued that States which acted early to stabilise population should not be penalised in the distribution of national resources. Senior Ministers from these States have at times remarked, in visible frustration, that they feel reduced to “beggars”, pleading for funds that constitutionally belong to them. This is not the language of political theatre. It reflects a genuine structural grievance about the terms on which States participate in the Indian Union.

Federal friction is visible not only in financial matters but also in the legislative process. In recent years, Governors in some States have sat for long periods over Bills passed by elected legislatures, effectively using the constitutional office as an instrument of political sabotage. Tamil Nadu and Kerala have witnessed particularly prolonged delays. The pattern is difficult to ignore: the delays have been in States that are governed by parties opposed to the ruling dispensation at the Centre. A Governor who withholds assent to legislation passed by an elected Assembly is, in effect, a second engine running in reverse.

Such delays have drawn judicial attention. In *State of Punjab vs Principal Secretary to the Governor of Punjab* (2023), the Supreme Court of India made it clear that a Governor cannot use inaction to stall the legislative process. The Court emphasised that the Governor’s office is not meant to function as a parallel political authority over an elected legislature.

More recently, in *State of Tamil Nadu vs Governor of Tamil Nadu* (2025), the Court observed that prolonged inaction by a Governor

Fairness, not political alignment, must guide India’s federal balance

Trump’s Section 301 weapon, lessons from the past

Within hours of the February 20 ruling of the United States Supreme Court that U.S. President Donald Trump lacked authority to impose his infamous reciprocal tariffs, the U.S. administration invoked Section 122 of the Trade Act of 1974 to impose a 10% temporary surcharge on imports, effective February 24 to July 24, 2026. Section 122 requires the existence of a “balance of payment” (BOP) crisis. This has already been challenged by 24 U.S. States in the United States Court of International Trade, on the ground that, like the preceding tariffs, these too have no legal basis, nor is there any BOP crisis facing the U.S.

Under World Trade Organization (WTO) rules of international trade, import restrictions, not tariffs, are permissible in limited situations involving serious BOP difficulties, which could arise due to actual or any imminent threat of serious decline in a country’s monetary reserves. None of these situations exists for the U.S.

In any event, since the Section 122 tariffs have a limited 150-day shelf life, Mr. Trump promised “other tools” and initiated two sets of “Section 301” proceedings – one alleging “Structural Excess Capacity and Production in Manufacturing Sectors”, and another alleging “Failure to Impose and Effectively Enforce a Prohibition on the Importation of Goods Produced with Forced Labor”. India is listed in both proceedings, along with the European Union (EU), Japan, Singapore, South Korea, China and many others. The factual and economic rationale for both, at best, is specious.

Furthering unilateral action

Section 301 sits under “Title III” of the U.S. Trade Act in the chapter “Enforcement of United States Rights under Trade Agreements and Response to Unfair Trade Practices”. Section 301 authorises the Office of the United States Trade Representative to investigate foreign trade practices and impose unilateral tariffs based on a determination that such practices are



R.V. Anuradha

is a Partner at Clarus Law Associates, New Delhi, specialising in international economic laws

unjustifiable, discriminatory, or restrict U.S. commerce, or violate trade agreements.

A clear anomaly in Section 301 is that it provides the U.S. the right to unilateral determination of what is governed by rules of international trade. To state the obvious, one cannot be the judge of one’s cause. To address this, soon after the WTO came into being in 1995, the EU initiated a dispute against the U.S. arguing that because Section 301 provides unilateral rights to the U.S. without any assessment of its international obligations, such a provision violated WTO law.

The WTO disputes panel agreed that even the threat of conduct prohibited by the WTO would enable one country to exert undue leverage on others. It compared Section 301 to a “big stick”, that, merely by being carried could be “as effective a means to having one’s way as actually using the stick”.

The panel, however, refrained from holding Section 301 as illegal based on an assurance from the U.S. administration that it would render determinations “in conformity” with its WTO obligations. This deference to the U.S. was predicated on the U.S.’s standing by that assurance. That deference has today come to haunt WTO members.

Now, key decimator

A 2020 report of the U.S. Congressional Research Service (CRS) notes that until the start of the Trump administration (in 2016), the U.S. stood by its word and used Section 301 primarily to build cases and pursue dispute settlement at the WTO. The report acknowledges that the Trump administration changed that and started using Section 301 as a weapon to impose tariffs as punitive measures. Pursuant to Section 301 proceedings against China in 2017, unilateral tariffs up to 25% were imposed. A WTO panel held in 2020 that these tariffs violated the U.S.’s commitments under the WTO. The U.S. did not blink and appealed the panel ruling to the WTO’s

The Section 301 proceedings demand action from India and other developing nations to revive multilateral rules

in assenting to Bills is constitutionally impermissible. These rulings together signal a firm judicial commitment to protecting the legislative sovereignty of elected State assemblies.

The experience of Delhi over the past decade provides a further illustration. Many initiatives of the elected government became entangled in disputes with the Lieutenant-Governor and the Union government. Courts eventually had to intervene. The lesson is not merely about one city; it is about what happens when the machinery of federal governance is used to punish a political opponent rather than serve the public.

Seen together – fiscal transfers, gubernatorial delays, and the Delhi impasse – these developments form a coherent pattern. The “double-engine” slogan is not merely a campaign metaphor. It is a description of how governance actually functions when political alignment is absent. And that is precisely the constitutional problem. The form of federalism survives; its spirit is quietly hollowed out.

India’s federal system has faced similar tensions before. In earlier decades, Article 356 was frequently misused to dismiss elected State governments. The Court’s landmark judgment in *S.R. Bommai vs Union of India* placed important limits on that practice. The challenge today is subtler: governments may remain in office, yet, governance itself may become hostage to political alignment.

Structural reform needed

What is needed is not merely judicial intervention, but structural reform. The Finance Commission’s recommendations could be made more binding. A fixed statutory timeline, say, three months, could be prescribed for Governors to act on Bills, failing which assent would be deemed granted. Inter-State/governmental councils, already provided for under Article 263, could be revitalised as genuine forums for cooperative federalism rather than ceremonial gatherings. These are not radical proposals; they are logical completions of the constitutional architecture that the framers intended.

Political slogans will continue to animate election campaigns. But a slogan that implicitly threatens citizens with slower development if they choose the “wrong” party at the State level does not merely distort electoral choice; it corrodes the constitutional promise of equal citizenship. Development cannot depend on political alignment. It must rest on rules and institutions that treat every State, and every citizen, with equal fairness. That constitutional balance, not the number of engines pulling the same train, is the only engine India’s federal democracy truly needs.

appellate process. The only catch was that there was no WTO Appellate Body by 2020, since the U.S. had, single-handedly, blocked its constitution.

The U.S., as the chief architect of the WTO, including its enforceable dispute settlement mechanism, has been its chief decimator. Had the panel in 1999 ruled that Section 301 required amendment to ensure WTO consistency, the U.S. – then a trustworthy member of the multilateral system that it had helped create – would very likely have amended the section to eliminate any possibility of unilateral tariff imposition. And Mr. Trump’s toolkit would have fallen short of one potent weapon.

The issue of trade agreements

Events over the past year have especially demonstrated the fragility of multilaterally agreed rules, and the significant systemic leverage the U.S. has been able to exercise by unabashed violation of those rules. And yet, we are also seeing some limits to that leverage. Malaysia has officially called its reciprocal trade agreement with the U.S. “null and void” after the U.S. Supreme Court’s decision. Unlike Malaysia, India had not yet signed an agreement with the U.S., and the government has indicated that it hopes for a “mutually beneficial trade agreement”. The pressures of the Section 301 proceedings will, no doubt, play a role in the conclusion of any negotiation.

Indian businesses need to actively participate in both Section 301 proceedings and make clear submissions exposing the absurdity of these so-called investigations. At the broader level, the core challenge for India and other developing countries is the need to revive multilateral rules. There is no substitute for the strength that comes from coalition-building to dilute the U.S.’s raw power advantage. India must step up and play that role.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Trump and war

The prosecution of the conflict with Iran under U.S. President Donald Trump reveals a disconcerting absence of strategic coherence and foresight. The presumption that targeted elimination of leadership would catalyse regime transformation has proven fundamentally flawed, as Iran has exhibited considerable

resilience against the United States-Israel offensive. Compounding this miscalculation is the administration’s oscillatory rhetoric — simultaneously proclaiming operational success while augmenting military deployments — thereby betraying policy inconsistency. Mr. Trump’s disparagement of NATO allies for their reluctance to engage

underscores growing diplomatic estrangement. Concurrently, internal dissent, exemplified by the resignation of Joe Kent, accentuates institutional unease. **N. Sadhasiva Reddy,** Bengaluru

U.S. President Donald Trump appears to recognise no limits. Earlier it was Venezuela; now it is Iran,

and he has openly suggested that Cuba could be next — without clear justification. These actions risk plunging entire nations into crisis and instability. Mr. Trump seems to view global resources, particularly oil, as instruments of power. The international community must respond firmly to check such unilateralism. Otherwise, there may be no

end to these escalating, authoritarian impulses. **N.G.R. Prasad,** Chennai

Military action without a clearly articulated endgame risks prolonged instability, rising human and economic costs, and unintended geopolitical consequences. The concerns raised within the United States Congress reflect not just partisan

debate but the need for strategic clarity, defined objectives, and an exit plan. As tensions with Iran escalate, restraint, transparency, and diplomacy must prevail over open-ended military engagement. **Gopalaswamy J.,** Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Building his own band of loyalists

CMYK

Cong. final list names seven for Assam polls

The Congress on Sunday announced its fifth and final list of seven candidates for the Assam Assembly election. With this, the party has declared candidates for 101 of the 126 seats in the State Assembly.

Among the candidates declared in the final list are Joseph Hasda from the

Gossaigaon seat, Birkhang Boro from Dotma-ST, Rajat Kanti Saha from Bijni and Anchula Gwara Daimary from the Bhergaon seat.

In an official statement, the party also declared Narayan Adhikari as its candidate from the Mazbat, Nirmal Langthasa from the Haflong-ST and Amar Chand Jain from the Katigorah Assembly constituency.

The elections to the 126-member Assam assembly will be held on April 9. Votes will be counted on May 4.



Congress cadre at a rally in Nagaon, Assam, recently.

Bengal likely to get 2,400 CAPF companies

About 2,400 companies of the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) are likely to be deployed in West Bengal for the upcoming Assembly election.

The Chief Electoral Office (CEO) of West Bengal has set up a joint committee to oversee the deployment based on the assessments of

vulnerability and sensitivity across polling areas. The committee held a meeting on Saturday at the CEO's office to decide on the number of personnel required in each Assembly constituency.

Since Saturday morning, Police Commissioners and Superintendents of Police have started visiting local police stations across the State to take stock of the ground situation.

About 480 companies of central forces have already been deployed by March 10.



The BJP's agenda was to use the SIR process to defeat Mamata Banerjee since she has defeated the saffron party for the last 15 years

SAGARIKA GHOSE
Trinamool Rajya Sabha member

7 candidates on Trinamool list for Assam

The Trinamool Congress has fielded an Assam MLA who stirred up a hornets' nest by suggesting a Miya Museum at a cultural centre in Guwahati five years ago. Sherman Ali Ahmed figured on the list of seven candidates announced by the Trinamool on Sunday. He is contesting from Mandia.



She [Mamata Banerjee] is emerging victorious, no matter how many officials are reshuffled by the Election Commission in collusion with the BJP

AKHILESH YADAV
Samajwadi Party leader



Poll rally: Mamata Banerjee addressing party workers in Kolkata on Sunday.

Mamata begins Bhabanipur campaign with workers' meet

Shiv Sahay Singh
Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister and Trinamool Congress chairperson Mamata Banerjee on Sunday began her campaign for the Bhabanipur Assembly seat with a workers' meeting. The meeting was held at Ahindra Mancha, with eight councillors of the Trinamool, including Minister Firhad Hakim, who is also a councillor from the area, among those present. With Bharatiya Janata Party leader Suwendu Adhikari contesting against the Trinamool chairperson, the Assembly seat in south Kolkata has become a prestige fight for both the parties.

The Trinamool shared photographs of the party chairperson addressing the meeting from its social media handles. "Today, Smt. @MamataOfficial set the tone for the battles ahead. Addressing party workers at Chetla, she called for relentless ground mobilisation, discipline, and an unbreakable connect with every household in Bengal," the West Bengal's ruling party said.

"At a time when Bangla-Birodhi forces are resorting to conspiracies, misinformation, and external interference, the message was unequivocal. We will not yield an inch."

The constituency located in the heart of Kolkata has electors from different communities, including Hindus, Sikhs, and Jains. Both Ms. Banerjee and her nephew, party general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, reside in the constituency. The Chief Minister has won three consecutive elections from the constituency in 2011, 2016, and 2021.

After losing to Mr. Adhikari in Nandigram in the 2021 election by a margin of 1,956 votes, Ms. Banerjee had contested and won from Bhabanipur in a byelection held in September 2021 by a margin of 58,832 votes, securing 72% of the total votes polled.

In the 2026 Assembly election, the contest has become interesting for two more reasons. First, the BJP had narrowed the gap with the Trinamool in the Bhabanipur Assembly seat during the 2024 Lok Sabha election, with the Trinamool's lead dropping to 8,297 votes in 2024 as against 58,832 votes in the 2021 Assembly election. In five wards of the Kolkata Municipal Corporation (63, 70, 71, 72, and 74), the BJP polled more votes while the Trinamool led in three wards – 73, 77, and 82.

The second important issue has been deletion of voters during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise. The SIR process, which has been controversial from the start in the State, saw the deletion of about 47,000 electors and another 14,000 being put to judicial adjudication in the constituency.

Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee had earlier this month said that despite the deletions due to SIR, she would win from Bhabanipur.

"I will win from Bhabanipur even if there is only one voter left on the voter list," the Chief Minister said on March 3, while addressing a gathering here.

Mr. Adhikari, who started the campaign a few days ago in Bhabanipur, has been playing up his chances of winning against the Chief Minister. The BJP leader is also contesting from Nandigram.

Amid the challenge from Bhabanipur and the first supplementary list of electors under adjudication set to be published on Monday, the Chief Minister postponed her visit to north Bengal. Instead of Tuesday, she will start campaigning in north Bengal on Wednesday.

BJP will draw a blank this time too

Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan does not see defections from the Left helping either the BJP or the Cong.; The Congress is BJP's 'B team', he says and rules out the BJP's Christian outreach working in its favour; The Left govt. should continue for the State to be in step with modern era, he adds

INTERVIEW

Pinarayi Vijayan

S. Anandan

Kerala Chief Minister and CPI(M) Polit Bureau member Pinarayi Vijayan is leading the Left Democratic Front's (LDF) charge on the hustings as the coalition seeks a third consecutive term in the State Assembly election on April 9. Just shy of 81, he exudes confidence of a win, pities the Congress for being the 'B team of the BJP' and predicts the BJP drawing a blank yet again, as he sits down for an interview with The Hindu at Pinarayi in his constituency, Dharmadam. Edited excerpts:

A large number of incumbent MLAs have been renominated by the Left front. No anti-incumbency?

There's no anti-incumbency because people feel that the government has strived to implement to the best of its abilities what the people wanted. Ten years ago, Kerala was in a shambles, but we brought about a sea change in all sectors. Now, our Vision 2031 delineates the achievable goals in each sector in order to de-

velop Kerala in step with the modern times.

If no institution from Kerala featured among the 100 top institutions nationally in 2016, eighteen Kerala colleges are on the list now. It's the result of active interventions, which call for a continuance.

We have fostered research, modern-day courses and skill development of the youth, linking the academia to industries. Our industry-friendliness is attracting top players from all over the world and everyone, except red industries, is welcome. We have a pre-eminent startup ecosystem.

But despite this, the Left suffered a jolt in the recent local body polls.

Each election follows a unique pattern. It was a local election, and we suffered setbacks at a few places which do not reflect the public sentiment across the State. We sense a favourable atmosphere now.

The BJP advances the 'develop Kerala' slogan but the Left accuses the Centre of stifling the State.

While it harps on 'develop Kerala' now, has the Centre done anything to develop Kerala? Despite repeated appeals and the stupendous feats in public health-



care, we have not got an AI-IMS. When the State was hit by disasters, the Centre not only turned its back, but blocked support from the countries which share a deep bond with Kerala. Did any other State in India receive such ignominious treatment in the face of a disaster? It was just us. Didn't it demonstrate a mentality that wanted to see the State perish?

The Centre sided with those who opposed on political grounds the K-Rail project meant to augment our transport infrastructure.

The State is denied its rightful share of taxes and our borrowing limit has been slashed considerably. Doesn't all this smack of vendetta?

What's your take on the BJP's Christian outreach and the Left's relationship with the community?

We have a good relationship with all communities. All sections of Christians, together forming a substantial community in the State, have a good relationship with the government. The BJP may harbour many desires, but nothing is going to materialise and there will be no consolidation in its favour.

How do you stop the BJP in its tracks? Who is better poised to do that, the Congress or the Left?

The Congress is unable to do that. It acts as the BJP's B-team, even nationally. Only the Left has steadfastly resisted the BJP, which it will continue even more vigorously. And the BJP is unlikely to make any electoral gain this time either.

Nationally, only a united front is possible against the BJP, but the Congress always foils such bids by vi-

DMK's allies find themselves politically squeezed

D. Suresh Kumar
CHENNAI

Alliances forged during elections often unravel within months of the results being declared. Parties routinely downplay such arrangements, describing them as mere "seat-sharing" exercises. This pattern has largely held true in Tamil Nadu as well.

An exception, however, has been the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance under Chief Minister M.K. Stalin, which has held together for nearly nine years. Its durability stems in large part from a shared anti-Hindutva ideological alignment among its constituents. Yet, this cohesion has not come without a cost. The ongoing seat-sharing negotiations for the April 23 Assembly elections have exposed underlying tensions, particularly among the alliance's smaller partners, who view the allocations as increasingly restrictive.

Of flexibility & firmness

In the case of its principal ally, the Congress, the DMK leadership had shown flexibility, conceding three additional seats and even a Rajya Sabha berth. This accommodation came despite publicly critical remarks by individuals close to Congress leader Rahul Gandhi. The Congress also exploited



Chief Minister M.K. Stalin with leaders of DMK alliance parties at an event in Kalaivanar Arangam in Chennai in June 2025.

the option of aligning with actor C. Joseph Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam to assert itself in negotiations.

By contrast, the DMK has adopted a firmer approach with its other allies, even reducing their seat allocations. The CPI, the CPI (M), the Viduthalaai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK), and the MDMK had aligned with the DMK in 2017. They found common ground in opposing the BJP's attempts to expand its footprint in Tamil Nadu, exploiting fissures in the AIADMK following Chief Minister Jayalalithaa's death in 2016.

These parties, along with smaller outfits such as the Manithaneya Makkal Katchi and Tamilaga Vazhuvirimai Katchi, played a significant role in shaping an anti-Narendra Modi political narrative by mobilising protests against various central policies and projects. Mr. Stalin successfully built on this platform to

Smaller parties found common ground with the DMK in opposing the BJP's attempts to grow in Tamil Nadu

channelise, anchor and capitalise on the political sentiment, benefiting the alliance as a whole in successive elections since 2019.

In the previous Assembly election, the CPI, the CPI (M), the VCK and the MDMK had settled for six seats each, even if they felt the number did not reflect their political weight. They justified the compromise as necessary "to keep the BJP at bay". This time, however, expectations were higher. Having remained loyal to the alliance, these parties anticipated a more favourable arrangement.

Instead, they have been offered fewer seats, with the DMK citing the need to accommodate new en-

trants. The CPI has been allotted five seats, the MDMK four (with three to be contested under the DMK's symbol), and the IUML two – down from three previously.

The Tamilaga Vazhuvirimai Katchi leader T. Velmurugan on Sunday exited the alliance, dissatisfied with its allocation of just one seat.

Lack of alternatives

For many of these long-standing partners, the current exercise has proven politically constraining. Deprived of feasible alternatives and growth opportunities, they are compelled to accept the terms set by the dominant partner. Questions have been raised, privately, about the DMK's decision to accommodate late Vijayakant's DMDK by offering it a Rajya Sabha seat and an undisclosed number of Assembly seats. This is seen by allies as disproportionate to the DMDK's diminished vote share of below half-a-percent.

Allies remain puzzled as to why a party that has shifted alliance positions with ease is being extended a privilege not afforded to more ideologically consistent partners.

The DMK's broader objective is clear: to contest a sufficiently large number of seats, 165 to 175, to secure a majority on its own. This goal inevitably limits

the space available for smaller partners.

The VCK, which has consistently articulated the concerns of Scheduled Castes and has been at the forefront of organising conferences against far-right positions, had sought eight to 10 seats in line with its recent growth in northern Tamil Nadu. The DMK, initially believed to be open to allocating eight seats, scaled it down to seven. On Saturday, party leader Thol. Thirumavalavan urged cadre to be prepared to accept the offer, emphasising the party's decisions are guided by long-term credibility, not short-term electoral gains.

The CPI(M), too, has found the reduced allocation difficult to accept. It held an extended meeting of its State secretariat on Saturday, attended by general secretary M.A. Baby. It entered discussions on Sunday with a mandate to seek at least six seats it had contested last time. However, Mr. Stalin remained firm on placing it on a par with the CPI. For now, State secretary M. Shanmugam has said the offer would be discussed further within the party.

As the election approaches, the alliance leadership is likely to project unity and rally behind a common political narrative. However, the discontent at the cadre level may prove difficult to manage.

Defeat of BJP must to save Assam, says citizen forum

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Days after activist-turned-MLA Akhil Gogoi's Rajior Dal joined the Congress-led bloc, a citizens' collective said the Opposition unity must translate into an anti-BJP verdict in the April 9 Assembly election in Assam.

The Assam Nagorik Samilani, led by academic Hiren Gohain and retired IPS officer Harekrishna Deka, said that the BJP's divisive politics had "hollowed out the Assamese identity from within". It said that the BJP-led government handed over the State's vital natural resources to multinationals over the past 10 years.

"The rule of law has vanished; the Chief Minister's word now passes for law. The people of Assam have no choice but to remove this government, and another five years in power would spell disaster for ordinary citizens," it said in a statement on Sunday.

Insisting that six Opposition parties striking a seat-sharing deal was a relief for the people seeking an alternative, it said their unity "must ignite a mass awakening" to defend democracy and confront the BJP.

Personal loan at lower cost

Santosh Agarwal

Personal loans are unsecured as lenders take risk by disbursing funds, without any collateral or guarantee. In this scenario, your credit score, which reflects past repayment behaviour, helps lenders in assessing the risk involved and taking a decision, as well as determining the interest rates in case the loan application is approved. Exhibiting strong creditworthiness generally helps borrowers get loans at better rates and terms.

Along with credit score, other pertinent factors also influence the likelihood of a borrower landing an offer with the best rates.

These factors include existing relationships with lenders, borrowers' debt-to-income ratio, income profile and more.

Maintain high credit score
Credit score is one of the primary metrics lenders use for pricing a loan. Credit score shows how dependable you are as a borrower.

Lenders usually prefer borrowers with scores above 750, signifying lower risk.

To maintain a good score, ensure timely repayments of all existing dues, keep your credit utilization ratio low and refrain from applying for multiple credit products within a short span of time. Consistent and disciplined behaviour helps build a strong credit score, giving you better leverage while negotiating interest rates and processing charges with lenders.

Compare multiple lenders
Comparing offers across lenders helps you easily scan and identify the best-suited offer. A simultaneous view helps in better analysis of rates and charges levied. A smarter approach involves comparing multiple loan offers in one place at financial marketplace platforms, rather than applying directly to several lenders, to minimise impact on the credit profile.

Relationship with lenders
Enquiring from the lender you have an existing relationship with can be a cost-effective way to borrow. Lenders extend pre-approved offers to select existing customers based on internal risk assessment. Your banking history or transaction record establishes the confidence of the lender in you. Because of this lower perceived risk, the lenders often provide better interest rates, faster approval, minimal documentation and sometimes lower processing charges on pre-approved loans.

Seasonal/festive offers
Keep an eye out for special offers from lenders from time to time. These personal loan offers are usually provided at discounted interest rates or with waived processing fees. Such offers are usually introduced during festive seasons for a limited period. Borrowers can time borrowing plans around such times to capitalise on these promotional offers and maximise their benefits.

Higher repayment prowess
Providing lenders with additional proof that shows higher repayment capability can also help in both the approval process and getting lower interest rates.

For instance, proof showing high income reduces the risk involved, as it shows higher repayment capacity. A higher income indicates a borrower is more likely to handle monthly repayments without financial strain. Additionally, higher income also reduces debt-to-income ratio, leaving the borrower with more disposable income to take on additional credit responsibly.

With low risk involved, borrowers can easily attract lower interest rates. Apart from these factors, another way to reduce your interest rate and processing fee is to negotiate with a lender when you have a high credit score, high income and fulfill all eligibility requirements.

In case your credit score is low, you can add a co-applicant with a stronger credit profile and stable income to increase the lender's confidence in your combined repayment capacity, which may help improve your eligibility, especially for high-ticket loans.

(The writer is CEO of Paisabazaar)



ILLUSTRATION-SAAI

NSEIX opens doors to U.S. stocks for Indian investors

From Apple to Alphabet, some of the world's biggest technology giants could soon find their way into Indian portfolios through NSEIX's Global Access platform

UNCLE SAM CALLING

Vaishali R. Venkat

For decades, buying U.S. stocks has been a Herculean task for most Indian investors. Strict remittance rules, a maze of paperwork, an arduous hunt for reliable and cost-effective overseas brokers, steep account-opening charges and the list of challenges goes on. On top of that, there are lingering concerns over overseas shareholdings' safety.

With technological advances, financial innovations and regulatory reforms, buying U.S. firms' shares from India may soon be an app/website away.

Thanks to the NSE International Exchange Global Access (NSEIX-GA). With NSEIX-GA, the line between Dalal Street and Wall Street blurs, bringing some of Silicon Valley's most valuable firms within Indian portfolios' reach.

Fully regulated
The NSEIX Global Access IFSC Ltd. is a subsidiary of NSE International Exchange (NSEIX), which in turn is owned by the National Stock Exchange (NSE) of India. It's a fully regulated entity operating from Gujarat International Finance Tec-City (GIFT City), Gandhinagar, under the regulatory framework of the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA). It enables investors to access global

Any Indian resident over age 18 can open an account with the NSEIX GA for free, through official website nseixga.com and get digitally onboarded

securities via IFSC ecosystem.

No paperwork
You can now directly buy stocks listed on the New York Stock Exchange (NYSE) and Nasdaq via NSEIX-GA which acts as a super broker.

Any Indian resident above 18 years of age can open an account with the NSEIX-GA for free, through official website nseixga.com and experience fully-digital onboarding. PAN/ Aadhaar card details could be automatically fetched via Digilocker with the KYC process done digitally.

No demat account
There is no need to open a separate demat account. Once an account is opened with the NSEIX-GA, individuals can start investing via the app or website. Investors can download NSEIX global access' mobile app with both Android and iOS versions available. Financial experts say the NSEIX Global Access' initiative would democratise how Indians gain access to international bourses. The NSEIX-GA, being a government-promoted institution, ensures the security

The entire technology platform/ process is designed in a manner that trades would be executed and settled in real time based on nations' market timings

of overseas holdings.

More foreign markets
Currently, the NSEIX-GA is ready with the offerings of U.S. stocks, especially NYSE and NASDAQ with plans afoot to connect with several other big global bourses. It is likely that almost 30 big foreign markets would be included soon. Plans are on to include Europe, the U.K., Japan, Korea and Australian markets too. With this, investors would have huge choice to diversify holdings.

An official said, "For a hassle-free back-end process, we have tied up with many countries as well as foreign brokers. The entire technology platform and the process is designed in a manner that trades would be executed and settled in real time based on the market timings of the respective countries."

For instance, the U.S. equity trades ideally follow T+1 settlement viz. trades would be settled one business day after execution. Therefore, funds or U.S. Securities become fully settled only after this settlement cycle completes."

Investors can remit mo-

ney from their bank accounts to the NSEIX-GA account in Gandhinagar Gift city and once the funds get reflected in the account, investors get trading limits power to buy shares.

Fractional investing
NSEIX-GA allows fractional investing viz. Indian investors can buy a portion/fraction of a U.S.-listed share rather than purchasing the entire stock. This can be particularly useful since many leading U.S. stocks trade at high prices.

Tax, RBI scheme
Capital gains on U.S. equities are not taxed in the U.S under the India-U.S. tax treaty. They are taxable only in India. Dividends attract a 25% U.S. withholding tax which can be later claimed as a foreign tax credit in India. Also, overseas investments are made under the Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS) which permits individuals to remit up to \$2.50 lakh/financial year. No Tax Collected at Source (TCS) applies on foreign remittances up to ₹10 lakh in a financial year while amounts above this attract TCS. Investors must also report overseas investments and income in Indian tax returns. Investors must, however, approach global markets with careful research, awareness of risks and understanding of cross-border regulations.

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)

Choices drive your decision

THINKINVESTOR

The choice between lump-sum investment and RCA leads to different behaviour; for most, diversification is investing in multiple funds with an intent to moderate future regret

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Do you 'diversify' when making lumpy investments and face many choices? Or "diversify" as you have underlying strategy to cut downside risk? Here, we discuss diversification heuristics which behavioural psychologists describe as how we behave when faced with many choices with large investment capital.

Choice matters

Suppose you decide to invest ₹5 lakh in equity funds. It is highly unlikely you will invest the entire sum in a single active fund. You may want to spread the money across, say, five funds. But the funds could have overlapping stocks. Why? Most people invest in large-cap, mid-cap, flexi-cap and thematic funds. There may be an overlap in stock holdings between large-cap and mid-cap funds as large-cap and mid-cap funds can hold up to 20% and 35% in mid-cap and large-cap stocks. There could be huge overlaps in holdings between flexi-cap style and thematic funds. This is because thematic, strategy and style indices are carved out of broad-cap index, the benchmark for flexi-cap funds. Ignoring the overlap, you may have significantly reduced anxiety by investing across these funds.

What if you equally spread the investment over 10 months through a systematic investment plan (SIP)? This is referred to as rupee-cost averaging (RCA). It is highly unlikely you will spread ₹50,000/month SIP across five funds. At the extreme, you may even invest in only one fund. Why?

It is typical behaviour to choose multiple funds when you invest lump-sum money and have several investment choices. This is referred to as diversification heuristics. This is our brain's way of moderating future regret. What if you invest the entire money in one fund and the funds you considered but did not choose those performing better? "Diversifying" across funds reduces this anxiety. We are arguably unlikely to suffer from diversification heuristics with RCA as the investments are spread across time and therefore, the investment performance is not so obvious.

Conclusion

The choice between lump-sum investment and RCA leads to different behaviour. We choose multiple funds when faced with simultaneous choices (lumpy investments) but not necessarily with sequential choices (RCA). The above was meant to bring to the fore a point on diversification – for most individuals, diversification is about investing in multiple funds with an intent to moderate future regret.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Small Finance Banks				
AU Small Finance Bank	7.10	6.35	7.10	6.75
Equitas Small Finance Bank	7.40	6.90	7.00	7.00
ESAF Small Finance Bank	8.00	4.75	6.00	5.75
Jana Small Finance Bank	8.25	7.00	7.50	7.77
Shivalik Small Finance Bank	7.80	6.00	6.75	6.25
slice Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.25	7.50	7.00
Suryoday Small Finance Bank	7.90	7.25	7.25	7.90
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	7.45	7.25	7.20	7.20
Utkarsh Small Finance Bank	7.50	6.00	7.50	7.00
Private Sector Banks				
Axis Bank	6.45	6.25	6.45	6.45
Bandhan Bank	7.25	7.00	7.00	5.85
City Union Bank	7.00	6.80	6.50	6.25
CSB Bank	7.00	5.00	5.75	5.75
DBS Bank	6.60	6.30	6.40	6.25
DCB Bank	7.15	6.90	7.00	7.15
Federal Bank	6.75	6.25	6.75	6.40
HDFC Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.40
ICICI Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.50
IDFC FIRST Bank	7.50	6.30	7.00	7.00
Indusind Bank	7.00	6.75	6.90	6.65

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Public Sector Banks				
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	7.25	6.75	6.65	6.60
IDBI Bank	6.50	6.20	6.35	6.25
Karnataka Bank	6.65	6.50	6.15	6.15
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.70	6.50	6.40	6.25
RBL Bank	7.20	7.00	7.20	6.70
SBM Bank India	7.85	7.10	7.10	7.00
South Indian Bank	6.70	6.35	6.20	5.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.10	6.80	6.60	6.60
YES Bank	7.00	6.65	7.00	6.75
Public Sector Banks				
Bank of Baroda	6.45	6.10	6.25	6.30
Bank of India	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.00
Bank of Maharashtra	6.65	6.20	5.25	5.00
Canara Bank	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
Central Bank of India	6.50	6.20	6.00	6.00
Indian Bank	6.60	6.10	6.05	6.00
Indian Overseas Bank	6.60	6.50	6.10	6.10
Punjab National Bank	6.60	6.25	6.30	6.10
Punjab & Sind Bank	6.75	5.85	5.85	5.95
State Bank of India	6.45	6.25	6.30	6.05
Union Bank of India	6.60	6.30	6.25	6.00

Home Loan Interest Rates

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Public Sector Banks			
State Bank of India	7.25-8.70	7.25-8.70	7.25-8.70
Bank of Baroda	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.25
Union Bank of India*	7.15-9.50	7.15-9.50	7.15-9.50
Punjab National Bank	7.25-9.10	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00
Bank of India	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.25
Bank of Maharashtra	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90
Punjab and Sind Bank	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70
Indian Overseas Bank	7.10 #	7.10 #	7.10 #
Indian Bank	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55
Central Bank of India	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15
Private Sector Banks			
Kotak Mahindra Bank	7.70 #	7.70 #	7.70 #
ICICI Bank	7.65 #	7.65 #	7.65 #
Axis Bank	8.00-11.90	8.00-11.90	8.00 - 9.10
HSBC Bank	7.45 #	7.45 #	7.45 #
South Indian Bank	7.20 #	7.20 #	7.20 #
Karur Vysya Bank	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65
Karnataka Bank	7.30-11.68	7.30-11.68	7.30-11.68

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
Federal Bank	8.30 - 10.75	7.30 - 10.75	7.30 - 9.75
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30
Bandhan Bank	8.41-12.58	8.41-12.58	8.41-12.58
RBL Bank	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
CSB Bank	8.05 #	8.05 #	8.05 #
HDFC Bank	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
City Union Bank	8.25-9.50	8.50-10.00	8.75-10.50
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
LIC Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Bajaj Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Tata Capital	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
PNB Housing Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
GIC Housing Finance	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
SMFG India Home Finance	10.00 #	10.00 #	10.00 #
Aditya Birla Capital	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
ICICI Home Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
Godrej Housing Finance	7.60 #	7.60 #	7.60 #
*Extra interest rate concession of 0.05% to borrowers opting for insurance policy Rates as on March 18 #onwards Source:Paisabazaar.com			

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.

Sport

A LOT TO DO

Pant is under pressure to deliver in IPL 2026, feels du Plessis



FILE PHOTO: SANDEEP SAXENA

Rishabh Pant is probably one player who is under immense pressure in IPL 2026. Some guys flourish under the pressure of the price tag, while some don't. Last season was really tough for him. The team struggled, and he also struggled with the bat. This IPL will be crucial for him — Faf du Plessis about the LSG skipper.

BASELESS

Kohli laughs off chartered flights to London reports ahead of IPL 2026



K. MURALI KUMAR

Royal Challengers Bengaluru batter Virat Kohli rubbished the reports of him requesting the RCB management for access to chartered flights between India and London during IPL 2026. Talking to Instagram, Virat posted one of these reports on his story along with laughing emojis, indicating that these reports are false.

IN & OUT

Shanaka set to replace injured Curran at Rajasthan Royals



AFF

Sri Lanka all-rounder Dasun Shanaka is set to replace the injured Sam Curran at Rajasthan Royals for IPL 2026. Shanaka is said to have informed PSL franchise Lahore Qalandars about the move. Curran, who was part of a pre-auction trade between CSK and RR, has a groin issue, which ruled him out of the IPL.

TOUGH CALL

Humpy withdraws from the FIDE Candidates tournament



FILE PHOTO: G.N. RAO

After deep reflection, I have taken the difficult decision to withdraw from the FIDE Women's Candidates tournament. Despite the assurances provided, I do not feel fully secure under the current circumstances. This is a painful but necessary decision, and I stand by it — Indian GM Koneru Humpy.

Batting-heavy Sunrisers hope to bowl rivals over

The Hyderabad franchise boasts some of the world's best T20 batters; in the absence of regular skipper Cummins, medium-pacers Harshal and Unadkat must do the heavy lifting among bowlers

Anirudh Velamuri

Sunrisers Hyderabad enters IPL 2026 with a familiar identity and one built on enviable batting firepower. On paper, it once again boasts the league's most formidable batting line-up that is capable of outscoring any opponent. Yet, some questions linger. Will this batting might be enough to carry it all the way? Can a largely inexperienced bowling unit, sans Pat Cummins for the opening matches, hold its own against IPL's big hitters? Focusing on its forte makes sense, but is it wise to be over-dependent on it?

Explosive line-up

To be fair to the team, Sunrisers' approach is not without logic. When your core features Abhishek Sharma and Ishan Kishan, two of the world's best T20 batters, you are naturally inclined to double down on that.

Add to it the explosiveness of Travis Head, Heinrich Klaasen and Nitish Kumar, the blueprint becomes clear — overwhelm, outscore and outlast the rivals.

IPL-19 COUNTDOWN
Sunrisers Hyderabad

OVERALL NUMBERS

	M	W	L	NR
	196	94	101	1

BY OPPONENT

	M	W	L	NR
CSK	22	7	15	0
DC	26	13	12	1
GT	6	1	5	0
KKR	30	10	20	0
LSG	6	2	4	0
MI	25	10	15	0
PBKS	24	17	7	0
RCB	25	14	11	0
RR	21	12	9	0

Sunrisers' remaining matches were against GL (5), RPS (4) and PWI (2)

SRH'S 2026 LEAGUE CAMPAIGN*

March 28	vs. RCB	Bengaluru	7.30 p.m.
April 2	vs. KKR	Kolkata	7.30 p.m.
April 5	vs. LSG	Hyderabad	3.30 p.m.
April 11	vs. PBKS	New Chandigarh	3.30 p.m.

*announced so far



ISHAN KISHAN

MIRACLE MAN

Taking the spotlight off 'Travishek' is no small task, yet Ishan Kishan enters IPL 2026 as Sunrisers' in-form batter. He rebuilt his game through domestic dominance and carried that momentum into the international arena. SRH's faith in his prowess is evident, with Kishan named stand-in captain while Pat Cummins works back to full fitness. Kishan leads by example as his Jharkhand teammates would attest. The 27-year-old could set the tone for a memorable campaign.

THE SQUAD

Ishan Kishan (Capt.), Abhishek Sharma (Vice-capt.), Pat Cummins, Travis Head, Aniket Verma, R. Smaran, Ishan Kishan, Heinrich Klaasen, Nitish Kumar, Harsh Dubey, Kamindu Mendis, Harshal Patel, Brydon Carse, Jaydev Unadkat, Eshan Malinga, Zeeshan Ansari, Salil Arora, Shivang Kumar, Sakib Hussain, Onkar Tarmale, Krains Fuletra, Praful Hinge, Amit Kumar, Shivam Mavi, and Liam Livingstone.

* Cummins has been ruled out of the first few matches



Locked in: Kishan in a conversation with head coach Vettori. SUNRISERS HYDERABAD

T. Natarajan) in the attack. Now, Harshal Patel and Jaydev Unadkat will have to shoulder that responsibility.

At the auction, the Hyderabad outfit, despite having the third-largest purse, turned to a mix of domestic seamers and promising prospects. Among the lesser-known names, young left-arm spinners Krains

Fuletra and Shivang Kumar stand out. Whether they are entrusted with meaningful tasks remains to be seen.

The home conditions, at least, offer some comfort. The Rajiv Gandhi International Stadium has traditionally produced flat, batting-friendly pitches, which the Hyderabad team used effectively in 2024 to

win five of its seven home games en route a runner-up finish. Ultimately, Sunrisers' season may hinge on a simple yet decisive balance. Its batting will win it games, perhaps many. If the bowling unit can rise from a point of vulnerability to one of reliability, this could be a complete side. If not, it risks a familiar story: spectacular but short.

COMPILED BY G. PRASAD & ANIRUDH VELAMURI

Anahat and Abhay make it a double delight at Indian Open

SQUASH

Sports Bureau
MUMBAI

It turned out to be a night of celebration for Indian squash fans as Abhay Singh and Anahat Singh won the men's and women's titles at the JSW Indian Open squash tournament on Sunday.

The men's title decider, an all-Indian battle, saw second-seeded Abhay overpower fourth seed Veer Chotrani 11-9, 11-8, 11-4 while Anahat cruised past Egypt's Hana Moataz 11-5, 11-6, 9-11, 11-6 in the women's final.

Abhay was in superb form on the big day. Although Veer put up a fight in the first two games, the second seed switched gears as the match progressed.

"Indian squash is very healthy right now with four men in the top 50 and Anahat is leading the charts in the Women's World Champs. Obviously, the goal individually is the Los Angeles Olympics, but we all have a big year ahead with the Asian Games," said Abhay.

Sublime show

Earlier, Anahat Singh produced a sublime show, coming up with a lethal combination of deception and speedy cross-court movement to leave her opponent in a daze.



Ruling the roost: Anahat and Abhay were hardly stretched in the title deciders. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

"I think it's really amazing how Hana played. She was not well the past week, reached the finals after a tough full-hour match on Saturday. She still came out and put on such a great

performance. It was amazing to watch. I'm glad we were able to put on a good fight for the audience and, hopefully, everyone had fun watching," said Anahat.

Araujo, 'keeper Garcia dazzle in Barca's win

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
BARCELONA

Ronald Araujo's header proved to be the difference as LaLiga leader Barcelona bagged a tight 1-0 win over Rayo Vallecano on Sunday.

Araujo nodded home Joao Cancelo's corner in the 24th minute to help the host earn the three points at Camp Nou, while goalkeeper Joan Garcia's superb display played just as big a part in the victory.

In Serie A, Como took control of the league's final Champions League spot by thrashing relegation-threatened Pisa 5-0 on Sunday. It was Como's fifth straight victory in Serie A.

In the Premier League on Saturday, Chelsea's hopes of Champions League qualification suffered another blow as Everton stormed to a 3-0 home win.

Beto struck twice before Iliman Ndiaye rounded off Everton's best win at its new home so far. Chelsea has now lost four consecutive games to put manager Liam Rosenior under pressure.

The results: LaLiga: Barcelona 1 (Araujo 24) bt Rayo Vallecano 0. **Premier League:** Newcastle 1 (Gordon 10) lost to Sunderland 2 (Talbi 57, Brobbey 90); Aston Villa 2 (McGinn 15, Watkins 68) bt West Ham 0; Tottenham 0 lost to Nottingham Forest 3 (Jesus 45, Gibbs-White 62, Awoniyi 87).

Serie A: Como 5 (Diao 7, Douvakis 29, Baturina 48, Paz 75, Perrone 81) bt Pisa 0. **On Saturday: LaLiga:** Espanyol 1 (Fernandez 68) lost to Getafe 2 (Duarte 45+3, Arambarri 45+7).

Premier League: Everton 3 (Beto 33, 62, Ndiaye 76) bt Chelsea 0. **Serie A:** Juventus 1 (Yidiz 14) drew with Sassuolo 1 (Pinamonti 52); AC Milan 3 (Pavlovic 37, Rabiot 54, Fofana 56) bt Torino 2 (Simeone 44, Vlasic 83-pen).

Bundesliga: Borussia Dortmund 3 (Bensebaini 73-pen, 84-pen, Guirassy 78) bt Hamburg 2 (Otele 19, Lokonga 38).



Top stuff: Araujo unlocks Rayo's defence with his headed goal. AFP



Precise hit: Ashique opens the scoring for Bengaluru with a left-footed strike. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Sanchez stars with a brace as BFC returns to winning ways

ISL

Sports Bureau

Braian Sanchez netted a brace as Bengaluru FC returned to winning ways in the Indian Super League with a 3-1 triumph over Inter Kashi FC in Kolkata on Sunday.

With the victory, Bengaluru climbed to fourth on the table with 11 points from six matches, three points behind leader Mumbai City FC. Inter Kashi is languishing in the 11th spot with five points off six games.

After finding its rhythm and dominating posses-

sion, Bengaluru broke the deadlock in the 20th minute. Ashique Kuruniyan pounced on a loose ball after an error from the Inter Kashi backline, and finished it off with a powerful left-footed shot.

But the host came back into the contest in the 38th minute. Alfred Planas made the most of a Nikhil Poojary slip that put him through one-on-one with Gurpreet Singh Sandhu, who could not prevent the equaliser.

Bengaluru, however, managed to restore the cushion. In the 69th minute, Sirojiddin's set-piece delivery was not gathered by Lluís Tarres, and San-

chez was present to head the ball in.

As Inter Kashi pushed for the leveller, the pressure got to the home team. Tarres played a false pass to Sanchez, who hit it first time from well outside the box to seal the deal for the visitor.

In Chennai, Sandesh Jhingan's header late in the match denied Chennaiyin FC a winning start at home. The contest ended 1-1.

The results: Inter Kashi FC 1 (Alfred Planas 38) lost to Bengaluru FC 3 (Ashique Kuruniyan 20, Braian Sanchez 69, 90+8).

At Chennai: Chennaiyin FC 1 (Irfan Yadwad 48) drew with FC Goa 1 (Sandesh Jhingan 88).

EDUCATIONPLUS

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H. Kalpana Rao

Earlier this year, I sent a New Year's card to a student who was visually impaired and was taken aback when he responded saying that he had used an AI tool that provided him with details of the layout, the colours, the pictures within the frame, and even the emotional framework of the image. The confidence with which he immediately pointed out that he was able to grasp the image's nuances through an AI-generated tool made a deep impression on me.

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is today being viewed as an advantage and a disadvantage in relation to academic integrity, learning ability, and evaluation. But the above incident compelled me to rethink the capacities of AI and the range of its possible uses within the field of disability.

Persistent difficulty
For years, instructors have devised innumerable ways to teach, educate, and communicate with students with diverse disabilities. Yet, one of the persistent difficulties has been enabling such students to participate fully in the classroom. For instance, a visually impaired student who had to dictate to a scribe invariably took longer than others to complete a writing task. Added to this was the scribe's own ability to write the dictated material correctly.

With AI, such students can dictate and use gener-



GETTY IMAGES/STOCKPHOTO

AI for inclusive education

While AI tools can help create an inclusive environment for students with disabilities, educators also should be aware of the problems involved

ative tools to produce responses. Of course, there is potential for misuse but, with appropriate monitoring, this challenge can be addressed.

Similarly, AI can be used to understand maps and charts and assist with reading quickly. Teachers can also create assignments that match the students' intellectual abilities, thereby instilling appropriate challenges. AI can also assist other kinds of disabilities, such as students with cerebral palsy, allowing them to transcribe their thoughts and

write meaningfully.

While teaching post-graduate students, I often faced challenges when working with visually impaired learners. Although I often read passages aloud and encouraged discussions so that all students could follow what was happening, there were moments when I would sometimes write key terms and references on the blackboard, forgetting that visually impaired students could not access what was written. Over the years, I became more aware of their needs and would

consciously speak louder so that they could record the audio. I also searched for e-books so that they could access the material independently.

But, in many Indian universities, teachers are not fully aware of how to create equitable and inclusive environments not because they lack the desire but because classrooms are often ill-equipped and have minimal technological access. Additionally, the heavy load of teaching and administrative work makes teaching feel like a burden

rather than a pleasure.

It is high time that educators in India become aware of the various tools and strategies emerging through AI to support students. More importantly, curricula and syllabi need to be co-designed with disabled students and instructors so that lived experiences can shape more effective learning. The need of the hour is for university administrators to ensure that faculty are trained to meet the needs of disabled students. Training in the use of and understanding how AI can

help innovate and support inclusive teaching practices is essential. Policymakers should also set guardrails to ensure that technologies remain unbiased and inclusive of diverse perspectives.

Cause of concern
While the use of AI is exciting, it is also a cause of concern. Many AI tools collect user data and store it and this could lead to unwanted data exposure. Moreover, there could be the potential for the data to be collected in methods that are not very transparent. As a result, it could create a risk between technological enhancement and surveillance, especially when data protection protocols are not well-crafted.

Yet another issue that needs to be tackled is that AI systems could be stereotypical, as they are generated using vast data sets and in cultures that may be different. As a result, it may misread the needs of individual students and create problems in assessment and evaluation. A third issue is that students could become too dependent on it and may not understand that it is only a tool to enable them to earn better. Yet, if teachers understand the principles of ethics, integrity, and moral responsibility, AI can become a powerful tool to enhance learning and knowledge among students with disabilities.

Progress Software has opened applications for the 2026 Progress Akanksha Scholarship for Women in STEM in India. This is a renewable four-year scholarship of up to ₹150,000 annually to support education-related expenses. Two recipients will be chosen based on academic achievement, financial need, interest and experience in

The writer is a former professor of English at Pondicherry University and now volunteers as the editor for the literary section of the online journal, *Muse India*. Email: hkalp.eng@pondiuni.ac.in

SCHOLARSHIPS

University of Bath School of Management Scholarships

Offered by the School of Management, University of Bath, the U.K.
Eligibility: Students who have accepted an offer for one of the eligible taught postgraduate Master's courses in 2026-27 and have applied for a scholarship within the deadline.
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Application: Online
Deadline: April 8
www.b4s.in/edge/UBMS2

Masters' Union Scholarship

Offered by Masters' Union
Eligibility: Students who have passed Class 12 and want to do a full-time UG programme in Business Management; Technology;

Leadership; Design; Sustainability; Finance and Economics; Marketing, or related fields and score in Masters' Union Scholarship Aptitude Test (MUSAT) or approved alternate test.
Rewards: Fee waivers ranging from 10-80%
Application: Online
Deadline: May 13
www.b4s.in/edge/MUSCASPI

ServiceScape Scholarship

Offered by ServiceScape.
Eligibility: Students above 18 years and enrolled or accepted in an accredited college, university, or trade school who submit an essay of 300-600 words on a topic provided by ServiceScape.
Rewards: \$1,000
Application: Online
Deadline: November 30
www.b4s.in/edge/SSSZ2

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

Women in STEM

Progress Software has opened applications for the 2026 Progress Akanksha Scholarship for Women in STEM in India. This is a renewable four-year scholarship of up to ₹150,000 annually to support education-related expenses. Two recipients will be chosen based on academic achievement, financial need, interest and experience in

Computer Science, Software Engineering, IT and/or Computer Information Systems and other criteria.
Eligibility: Indian citizens who are women and enrolled in the first year of a Computer Science, Computer Science Information Technology or related courses with an aggregate of 75% or more in Class 12 and a family income not exceeding ₹500,000
Deadline: April 13
For details visit <https://tinyurl.com/sr764hne>



OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

I am doing B.Sc. Biotechnology, but my goal is the Civil Services. I want to study Sociology, English, and Ethics at the PG level. How can I align this with my plans? Ayush

Dear Ayush,
Civil Services does not require a specific undergraduate degree, nor does it require continuity between UG and PG subjects. Your interests in Sociology, English, and Ethics are highly aligned with UPSC. Biotechnology will be very useful for General Studies to answer questions in science and technology. So it is also a helpful foundation.

Your Postgraduate choices could be M.A. Sociology (GS-I (Society)) and GS-IV (Ethics) and the Essay paper. M.A. English will help in writing and articulation, the Essay paper and the possibility of choosing English as the optional paper. A PG Diploma in Ethics or Public Policy will help with Ethics Case Studies, governance issues and also help in the interview stage.

I finished Class 10 in 2020 and chose PCMB, aiming to join the Indian Air Force but missed the NDA's age eligibility. Due to CUET's introduction, I could not secure college admission but enrolled in an online BCA programme. In 2024, I got admission to the B.Sc. Maths (Hons). I am also preparing for the CDS and AFCAT. If the defence forces doesn't work, I plan to build a stable career as a data analyst. I have completed a data analytics bootcamp, developed skills such as Excel, SQL, Python, Tableau, Power BI, and cloud tools. What should my next steps be? Nitin

Dear Nitin,
Your path looks a little

Approach is key

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

'zig-zag' on paper but it showcases your resilience, adaptability, and clarity of intent. You already know CDS/AFCAT are the direct routes but keep a time-bound plan and don't put your life on hold for this. Create blocks of two to three hours dedicated to preparing for each task. Keep your Plan B also alive and active since you already have great momentum. Your Maths (Hons.) background, analytics tools stack, and bootcamp exposure give you a good foundation for a data analyst role. Now, you need to focus on projects, internships or live work and visibility. Work on building four to five solid end-to-end problem-based projects and host them on GitHub, Medium/Notion. Get some analytics experience via internships, contract roles, or projects in NGOs, research organisations or start-ups. Leverage your Maths (Hons)

knowledge and learn statistics for data analysis, hypothesis testing, probability concepts, and basic econometrics. Work on your resume and profile. Network and connect with analysts on LinkedIn.

I finished B.Com in 2025. I am from a Hindi-medium background and aim to study in a top B-school. I attempted the CAT a year ago, but did not score well. I am working on my quantitative and logical reasoning skills. How do I improve my English? Rajnandan

Dear Rajnandan,
Being from a Hindi-medium background is not a disadvantage. Poor English is a skill gap, not an identity problem. Work on speaking with clarity, confidence, expressing ideas logically, and comprehending what is being said. Read

comprehension passages and work on CAT-relevant grammar. Your vocabulary doesn't need to be fancy but you should be able to express what you think and feel. Practise mock interviews in English where you answer structured views, opinions, and check your confidence in delivery. Read the English newspaper every day out loud, underline the ideas, summarise them in English and get someone to check it. Practise speaking for around 15 minutes daily and record yourself. Start with simple everyday topics. Focus on your thoughts and expression. Start to think in English and try not to translate from Hindi to English. Also improve writing skills by doing short essays on any topic twice a week. Use positive affirmations and be proud of your roots and where you come from.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge



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I will go forward through runs and runs only

Smaran had a stupendous sophomore season as he accumulated a tournament-high 950 runs in the 2025-26 Ranji Trophy. After a sedate start to his domestic career in 2024, the 22-year-old from Karnataka has emerged as one of the brightest prospects in the country across formats

INTERVIEW

R. Smaran

N. Sudarshan

There is a studious zeal to how R. Smaran goes about his cricket. While batting, he is focused and efficient and not outrightly flashy and extravagant. While speaking, he is both poised and confident without sounding overtly cerebral and nerdy. These facets found wholesome expression in the 2025-26 Ranji Trophy as Smaran, 22, scored a chart-topping 950 runs in Karnataka's first run to the final in over a decade.

What made it all the more remarkable was the fact that the performance came when the side had accomplished batters Karun Nair and Devdutt Padikkal for a majority of the games, and K.L. Rahul for the last four.

The campaign may have ended in an anti-climax – he was out first ball to the sensational Jammu & Kashmir pacer Auqib Nabi in the final and Karnataka lost out on adding to its eight Ranji crowns - but the last time anyone younger than Smaran finished as the highest run-getter in India's premier red-ball tournament was when a 21-year-old Shreyas Iyer made 1321 runs in 2015-16.

Smaran, under whose captaincy Karnataka won its maiden C.K. Nayudu (U-23) Trophy in 2023-24, spoke to *The Hindu* on his superlative season, his batting methods and mindset, and the upcoming IPL with Sunrisers Hyderabad. Excerpts:

How does it feel to be the highest run-getter in the Ranji Trophy?

It's a great feeling. I set out at the beginning of the season with certain goals - score 1000 runs or remain at the top of the run charts. I fell short by 50 runs, but to be top is great. I am really grateful to god for giving me the platform and that many games to get those many runs.

You debuted in 2024-25. How different was season two from season one?

This time we went till the final in Ranji Trophy and I got to play that many more games in different conditions. There were a lot of learnings as to how I can tackle spin better, play fast bowlers better on a green top. We had a lot of experienced guys who play for the country joining us from the knockouts. We missed out on winning, but I learnt a lot both by being there in the middle and in the dressing room.

How did you sustain your red-ball form, across nine matches and nearly five months? Ranji is now played in two parts and the white-ball competitions are sandwiched...

The preparation in the off-season is done in the same way. You quickly switch between formats and practice in such a way that you don't have much time to adjust. When you move from white ball to red, most batters tend to go for their shots and continue the same momentum. But red ball requires patience. You can still play your shots, but you need to know what your game is and how there's a pattern to scoring runs.

Do you have a favourite knock?

The Mumbai one (83 n.o. in the fourth innings) would be my favourite. It was against Mumbai in Mumbai and when the situation was against us. We were three down [for 119], and chasing 325 is never easy. There was a small amount of nerves going in because in the three innings before that I hadn't got runs. It was a do-or-die situation, but after I got a couple of boundaries in the first four-five balls, I eased a bit.

Rahul at the other end guided me as to what shots I could play and which bowlers to take on. We quickly put on 70-80 runs, and the field started spreading out. That knock is right up there.

What were you most pleased about?

The way I handled pressure after



NIRMAL HARINDRAN

Rahul got out. Shreyas Gopal and Kruthik Krishna were also out quickly [with 40 runs needed], but the way I handled the pressure to take the game deep, rotate the strike and not go for the big shots... that is something I rate highly.

How have you progressed as a batter, from age-group cricket to the senior side?

Not many major changes technique-wise, but just about putting more value on your wicket. In the longest format, it is easy to throw away your wicket when you are settled.

It is important to know your gameplan, bat the opposition out of the game and give your bowlers the time to get 20 wickets.

I have had a lot of conversations with our coach Yere [Goud] sir, and with Karun and a lot of senior players about this.

Three of your six First Class centuries are double hundreds, and the three others are 135, 134 and 127. What's with you and big knocks?

It's just the hunger to convert hundreds into big hundreds. In India, you have so many talented players and almost every other guy gets a century.

The only way you can differentiate yourself from others is by scoring 160, 170 and double hundreds.

The emphasis is also on giving our bowlers enough time. If I get out immediately after my century, the new guy will find it hard.

In Karnataka's 2024-25 Vijay Hazare Trophy triumph, you made 433 runs including a century in the final. In two editions of Syed Mushtaq Ali T20, you have a strike-rate of around 160. What has worked for you across formats?

Preparation in the off-season. Like I said before, you bat two-three days of red ball and then switch to white ball. But even in the shorter formats, it's very important to know your game. For me, even if it's in T20s, it is essential to observe those initial four-five balls.



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nowadays, you don't have that luxury, and that is something I'm really working on. But for playing different formats, a lot of credit goes to my coach Syed [Zabiulla] sir and the regimen he put forward.

Being an all-format batter in India is tough. India's Test and ODI captain [Shubman Gill] is not even there in the T20 team. How much work goes into compartmentalising your approaches?

A lot. When you make the switch, sometimes you still are in the past format.

Personally, I feel, anything that you do out there in the middle is a result of repeated practice.

The more repetitions you do, it becomes easier. Playing all three formats is never going to be easy. Practice has to be put into all three equally to ensure you excel.

I wanted to wind back a bit. Before you made your Karnataka debut in October 2024, your age-group teammates such as K.V. Aneesh, or the very young Hardik Raj, had already made the grade. Was there a feeling that your progress was slow? How confident were you that you will eventually get there, especially having once missed out on a U-19 India slot?

During that U-19 phase, I thought it was all about playing U-19 India. I didn't even think about Ranji because U-19 India had so much value. But immediately after that, I kept no expectations.

When I played C.K. Nayudu Trophy, I felt that good things will always come to good people. I just needed to keep my head down and keep scoring.

Even when guys around me were going ahead and playing Ranji Trophy, I felt that they were going there because they had scored a lot of runs and taken a lot of wickets.

I believed my due will come. Even now, the only way I'll go forward is through runs and runs only.

The C.K. Nayudu championship win

really helped personally and I got my due.

Your first five Ranji Trophy matches were unremarkable, with a highest of 37. Can you talk about that period?

It's a very proud feeling to represent your State and a lot of expectations come with it. Like any other player, I felt that I needed to cement my place. But I forgot to enjoy the game and the process of getting those big runs. In those five matches, I was not in the right headspace. But after that, we went into the Syed Mushtaq Ali and Vijay Hazare trophies and I spoke to a lot of people. They told me to enjoy the game and not worry about the outcome.

I started doing that, and one thing led to the other. In the span of one-and-a-half months, we had the Vijay Hazare Trophy in our hands. It helped me build momentum for the second half of Ranji, and I got the double hundred against Punjab (203).

The IPL is next, and what are your expectations? You came in as a replacement player for Sunrisers in 2025 but didn't play because you got injured. But the franchise retained you, and you will now be with some of the best T20 players like Abhishek Sharma, Travis Head, Heinrich Klaasen...

I am very grateful to Sunrisers for having put their faith in me even though I was ruled out of the IPL last year.

They back a lot of youngsters, and I am looking forward to fulfilling whatever role is given to me.

The IPL is a long tournament and momentum is a big factor. With guys like Abhishek and Ishan [Kishan] coming in from the T20 World Cup win, it is going to help us.

To play with those who have dominated the T20 format over the past two, three years is a great thing.

It will help me assess my own game and improve. We reached the final two years back and we won in 2016. Hopefully, we can replicate 2016 in 2026.

How agriPV can turn India’s farms into dual-purpose powerhouses

India’s ambitious energy transition goals — to have 300 GW of installed solar capacity by 2030 and achieve net-zero emissions by 2070 — put land at a premium, and utility-scale solar projects require large tracts of land while agriculture is already under pressure from competing land use; agri-photovoltaics can ameliorate this conflict

Shantanu Roy

In the 2026-27 Budget, the outlay for the PM-KUSUM scheme nearly doubled to ₹5,000 crore, signalling the government’s renewed emphasis on increasing solar power production centred on India’s farmers. Specifically, the scheme aims to provide energy and water security to farmers, enhance incomes, and decarbonise the farm sector through decentralised solar pumps and power plants.

But as the scheme evolves, India also faces a question: how can solar be expanded on agricultural land without compromising food security?

Agri-photovoltaics (agriPV) is emerging as a promising answer to this question. AgriPV integrates solar systems with farming, allowing farmers to generate electricity and cultivate crops on the same parcel of land. The panels are mounted at a suitable height to allow farm operations below, and are spaced between crop rows or integrated into greenhouses to minimise conflict between agricultural production and energy generation.

Selecting right crops

The designs vary by crop and region. Elevated systems have panels mounted a few metres above ground to allow crops to grow below. Row-based systems have panels positioned between crop rows to minimise shading. Vertical systems use upright panels that can capture sunlight from both sides. Greenhouse-integrated systems feature solar panels on roofs or walls to maintain a controlled growing environment. The suitability of a design also depends on the local climate, irrigation practices, and the crop. So systematic and region-specific planning is essential to optimise both agricultural and energy yields.

Careful crop selection is also key to the success of agriPV systems because the amount of sunlight available changes based on how solar panels are placed. Shade-tolerant crops generally perform well in partially shaded areas under solar panels while crops that need more sunlight grow better in the spaces between rows of panels.

Crop selection also varies across India’s diverse agro-climatic regions. For instance, suitable crop options include tomato, onion, garlic, turmeric, ginger, leafy vegetables, and tulsi in Madhya Pradesh, and ragi, jowar, grapes, tomato, potato, chillies, banana, and brinjal in Karnataka and Maharashtra – all of which can perform well in agriPV systems.

Beyond technical considerations such as crop selection, the scalability of agriPV hinges on developing viable business models. Farmers can own and operate agriPV systems, use a portion of the electricity generated, and sell the surplus. With the help of Farmer Producer Organisations or cooperatives, multiple



Sheep graze under rows of solar panels on a farm. Representative image. PUBLIC DOMAIN

farmers can also aggregate land and collectively develop projects, enhancing their bargaining power and access to finance.

Private developers could also lease farmland and share revenues or pay fixed rents to farmers. Alternatively, State governments or public agencies could develop agriPV systems to support local energy needs.

Why agriPV matters for India

India’s ambitious energy transition goals – to have 300 GW of installed solar capacity by 2030 and achieve net-zero emissions by 2070 – put land at a premium. Utility-scale solar projects require large tracts of land while agriculture is already under pressure from competing land uses.

AgriPV can ameliorate this conflict. With more than half of India’s land under agriculture, dual-use deployment is valuable. And in an economy that depends heavily on agriculture, the technology’s appeal lies in both farmers diversifying their incomes and producing clean energy. Farmers can earn from selling electricity, leasing land or sharing revenues while continuing to cultivate.

AgriPV also delivers environmental co-benefits. In certain agro-climatic conditions, partial shading can reduce evapotranspiration – the combined loss of water to the atmosphere through evaporation and plant transpiration – and soils retain more moisture, thus enhancing the overall water-use efficiency. Solar panels can also protect crops against extreme heat, rainfall, and hail. By lowering the farm’s need for diesel, such systems can also support

AgriPV’s large-scale adoption in India faces economic, regulatory, and institutional barriers, which include high capital costs, lack of regulatory clarity and lack of design benchmarks

rural entrepreneurship and local economic growth. AgriPV can power ancillary services as well, including cold storage, food processing units, and chaff cutters, strengthening rural value chains. However, this requires clear governance frameworks, tariffs, and accessible finance.

Status in India

There are around 50 pilot agriPV installations nationwide, with various panel-crop combinations and economic feasibility under evaluation. Recent policy discussions have also increasingly referenced agriPV but large-scale replication has yet to commence. Both policymakers and experts need more empirical evidence across agro-climatic zones to say which configurations, crop matrices, and financial frameworks are most suitable.

The technology’s large-scale adoption in India does face economic, regulatory, and institutional barriers. Elevated structures and specialised mounting systems significantly increase capital costs, well above those of conventional solar systems. A crop’s responses to shading can vary and poorly designed systems may even reduce agricultural yields.

System ownership between farmers

and developers could also raise doubts, particularly if long-term land rights and revenue-sharing arrangements are not fully clear. Land classification, grid connectivity, and tariffs hinge on regulatory clarity and the lack of design benchmarks adds to investor uncertainty.

Policy pathways

With the right policy support, agriPV has the potential to scale beyond pilot projects. Recent consultations on PM-KUSUM 2.0 have indicated that the government may include agriPV in a proposed ‘National Agri-photovoltaics Mission’ as a dedicated 10-GW component, with viability gap funding to offset the capital costs. Such measures could remarkably improve the bankability of agriPV projects and reduce the financial risk. Clearly recognising dual-use configurations within PM-KUSUM 2.0 could help align agriPV with farmer-centric solarisation. States can reinforce this by identifying suitable clusters, streamlining approvals, and integrating agriPV into farmer training and advisory programmes.

As India rapidly advances in its energy transition, agriPV offers a pathway for renewable energy to complement agricultural productivity. Its inclusion under PM-KUSUM 2.0 could move it from scattered pilots to a more structured, scalable model, strengthening farmer incomes and easing land pressures.

(Shantanu Roy is the Sector Coordinator of the Renewables and Energy Conservation sector at the Center for Study of Science, Technology and Policy (CSTEP), a research-based think tank. shantanu@cstep.in)

THE GIST

Agri-photovoltaics (AgriPV) integrates solar systems with farming, allowing farmers to generate electricity and cultivate crops on the same parcel of land

The panels are mounted at a suitable height to allow farm operations below, and are spaced between crop rows or integrated into greenhouses to minimise conflict between agricultural production and energy generation

In an economy that depends heavily on agriculture, the technology’s appeal lies in both farmers diversifying their incomes and producing clean energy

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BIG SHOT



Ugandan rangers handle a rhino at the Kidepo Valley National Park following the first wildlife exchange between Kenya and Uganda as part of a wider effort by conservation groups and the Uganda Wildlife Authority to rebuild a national population wiped out by poaching, in the Karamoja region of northeastern Uganda on March 17. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

MPC: confirming new moons

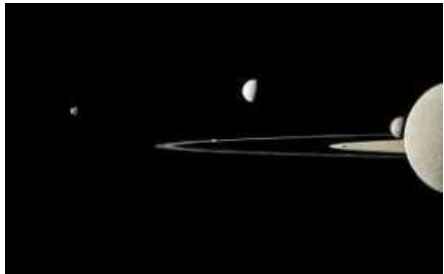
Vasudevan Mukunth

Last week, the Minor Planet Centre (MPC) announced 15 new moons had been found, four around Jupiter and 11 around Saturn. The Jovian moons were found by the U.S.-based Scott Sheppard and David Tholen and the Saturnian ones by a team led by Edward Ashton in Taiwan.

The MPC is the world’s primary repository for all observations of small bodies in the solar system. Located in Cambridge, Massachusetts, it operates at the Smithsonian Astrophysical Observatory under the International Astronomical Union, and plays a vital role in tracking asteroids, comets, and the moons of the outer planets.

When astronomers discover a new object, they send their data to the MPC, where experts verify the observations and calculate the object’s orbit. If the discovery is new, the MPC assigns it an official designation. This process ensures every known minor planet has a unique identity and a predictable path.

One of the MPC’s most critical jobs involves monitoring near-earth objects (NEOs). NEOs are space rocks that could potentially threaten the earth. With support from NASA’s Planetary Defense Coordination Office, MPC maintains a large database that allows scientists to



On July 29, 2011, the Cassini mission captured five of Saturn’s moons in a single frame with its narrow-angle camera. NASA/JPL-CALTECH

predict if and when a rock might come close to the earth.

The MPC also facilitates communication within the global scientific community by publishing electronic circulars that alert researchers to new discoveries or interesting celestial events. These updates allow observatories worldwide to coordinate their efforts and gather more data quickly.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to **science@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Daily page’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of trips under free bus travel scheme since inception

898 crore. Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. K. Stalin on Sunday hailed the success of the 'Vidyal Payanam' free bus travel scheme for women, stating that the initiative has recorded nearly 898 crore trips since its inception. PTI

Number of dog-bite cases in Rajasthan in 2025

900 An RTI application revealed that the State reported more than 460 dog-bite cases in 2024, which rose to over 900 in 2025. Jaipur recorded the highest numbers both years, with cases surging from 307 in 2024 to 633 in 2025. PTI

Percentage increase in Sri Lanka's fuel prices due to conflict

25 in per cent. Sri Lanka raised fuel prices by 25% on Sunday, as the country prepared for more impact from the war in West Asia. Regular petrol was increased to 398 rupees (\$1.30) per litre, up from 317 rupees, while diesel rose by 79 rupees to 382. AFP

Education systems with a national ban on phones in schools

114 More than half of the countries have banned phones in schools amid mounting concerns about declining attention in classrooms and cyberbullying, according to the UNESCO's Global Education Monitoring team. PTI

People killed in a strike on a hospital in Sudan

64 At least 64 people were killed, including at least 13 children, in a strike on a hospital in Sudan's western Darfur region last week, the World Health Organization said on Saturday. AP
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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What insurance numbers do not reveal

Insurance penetration and density are widely used indicators, but they show premium collection, not how well households are protected against loss of income; as a result, premium growth is often mistaken for progress, even when financial protection remains limited

ECONOMIC NOTES

T.C. Suseel Kumar
R. Sudhakar

India is often described as an “underinsured” country. This claim is usually backed by two numbers that appear regularly in official speeches, policy papers, and media commentary: life insurance penetration and density. Low values of these indicators are taken as proof that insurance coverage in India is inadequate and that large sections of the population remain unprotected.

The problem is not that these numbers are wrong. The problem is that they are misunderstood – and then used to draw the wrong conclusions during public discourses.

In everyday economic language, penetration refers to how widely a product is used. Mobile phone penetration, for example, tells us what proportion of people or households have access to a phone. Density usually means how much of something exists per person.

In life insurance, however, these terms mean something quite different. Insurance penetration is defined as the total premium collected by insurers as a percentage of gross domestic product (GDP). Insurance density is the average premium paid per person, usually expressed in U.S. dollars. These definitions are internationally accepted and are useful for comparing the size of insurance markets across countries.

But these measures do not tell us what most people assume they do. They do not reveal how many families are insured, whether those families would be financially secure if the main earning member were to die, or whether insurance is serving its most important social purpose – protecting households against sudden loss of income.

What the numbers show

Premium-to-GDP, for instance, is essentially a measure of industry revenue relative to the size of the economy. It can move up or down for many reasons that have little to do with household protection. If the economy grows rapidly



GETTY IMAGES

due to infrastructure spending or increased exports, insurance penetration can fall even if more people are buying insurance.

On the other hand, insurers can push high-premium products and raise penetration figures without meaningfully improving protection.

Regulatory changes can further distort the picture. When product rules or commission structures are modified, premium growth often slows temporarily as insurers recalibrate. Penetration may then appear to decline. This does not mean fewer families are insured – it simply reflects a shift in how insurance is sold and priced. Treating such movements as evidence of poor coverage leads to confused diagnosis and poor decision-making.

Insurance density has similar limitations. It is often used to compare India with richer countries, leading to the conclusion that Indians are underinsured because they spend less on insurance. But such comparisons ignore income levels and cost of living. A family paying a modest premium in India may be making a far greater financial commitment, relative to income, than a family paying a higher premium in a developed economy.

Premium vs protection

More importantly, both penetration and

density confuse how much is paid with how much protection is received. In India, insurance products have long been sold as savings instruments rather than as pure protection. As a result, premiums can be high even when the life cover provided is modest. Premiums rise, but the financial security of dependents does not improve proportionately.

This gap between premiums and protection becomes clearer when claims data are examined. According to the IRDAI Annual Report 2024-25, life insurers settled a little over 10 lakh individual death claims during the year, paying a total of about ₹33,000 crore. This translates to an average payout of roughly ₹3.3 lakh per claim, showing a 97% claim settlement ratio.

While this reflects efficient claim settlement, it also indicates the level of financial support that life insurance typically delivers to bereaved families. For most households, such an amount would replace income for only a short period, if at all. Yet these claim payouts fully count towards insurance penetration and density. The numbers look reassuring, even though the underlying protection is often thin. This is why headline indicators can suggest progress while households remain financially vulnerable.

This confusion matters because it shapes how the problem is framed.

Rethinking adequacy

When India is labelled “underinsured” on the basis of these metrics, the implied conclusion is that people lack awareness or access. In reality, many households – especially in the formal and semi-formal sectors – already own at least one life insurance policy, either individually or through employers. The real issue is not reach, but adequacy. Families may have insurance, but not enough to replace lost income if something goes wrong.

This is not an argument for abandoning penetration and density altogether. These indicators are useful for tracking the growth of the insurance industry and for making broad international comparisons. But they are poorly suited to guiding public policy aimed at household protection. When revenue-based measures are treated as indicators of social security, they obscure more than they reveal.

A more meaningful approach would begin with simpler, more direct questions: how many households actually have some form of life insurance cover – whether individual, employer-provided, or through government schemes? And for those that do, how much life cover do they have relative to their income? These questions focus on protection, not premium collection.

Such measures are often dismissed as difficult to compute. In reality, much of the required data already exists – in regulatory filings, census household counts, and records of group insurance schemes. The goal need not be perfect precision. For public policy, understanding broad gaps in protection is far more important than tracking exact premium flows.

As long as India continues to rely on penetration and density as shorthand for insurance adequacy, the debate will remain confused. Premium growth risks being mistaken for progress, and industry expansion will be equated with social security.

Clear thinking begins with clear measurement. In life insurance, that means shifting the focus from how much money is collected to how well families are protected.
(T.C. Suseel Kumar is a former Managing Director of LIC and R. Sudhakar is a former Executive Director of LIC)

THE GIST

Insurance penetration and density are often misunderstood and do not reveal how many families are insured or whether they would be financially secure if the main earning member were to die.

The real issue is not reach but adequacy, as households may have life insurance but not enough cover to replace lost income, leaving them financially vulnerable.

Is compulsory voting feasible in the Indian context?

How can voter turnout be increased without making voting mandatory?

Rangarajan R.

The story so far:

The Election Commission has announced the poll schedule for five Assembly elections to be held in April-May 2026. In a separate hearing before the Supreme Court on a poll-related matter, the court raised questions regarding mandatory voting in elections.

What is the right to vote in India?

Article 326 of the Constitution grants every citizen the right to vote without any discrimination. It provides that any citizen who is not less than 18 years old and is not otherwise disqualified under the Constitution or any law on certain grounds is entitled to be registered as a voter.

Section 19 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, requires a citizen to be at least 18 years old and ordinarily resident in a constituency to be registered as an elector. Section 62 of the Representation of the People Act, 1951, provides the right to vote to every person whose name is entered in the electoral roll of a constituency. In various cases, the Supreme Court has held that the right to vote is a statutory right.

Should voting be made compulsory?

Voting is essential for a functional democracy, but it is neither a fundamental duty nor a legal duty in India. Proposals for compulsory voting have long been debated.

The Dinesh Goswami Committee on electoral reforms, set up in 1990, did not favour compulsory voting, citing practical

difficulties in implementation. Instead, it recommended improving voter participation through awareness campaigns.

The Law Commission, in its 255th report (2015), discussed the issue in detail. Compulsory voting does result in increased voter turnout by an average of about 7%. Nevertheless, this increase in participation is a direct corollary of the severity and strict enforcement of penalties for not voting.

Some democracies, such as Australia and several Latin American countries, have provisions for compulsory voting. In Australia, Argentina, and Brazil, voters may be fined if they fail to vote without valid reasons. In Peru, certain public goods and services are denied to non-voters.

Penalising non-voters by imposing fines

or restricting their access to government services is an extremely harsh measure that will not work in the Indian context. From a constitutional perspective, compulsory voting could be seen as violating the fundamental right to freedom of expression under Article 19(1).

What can be the way forward?

Low voter turnout can result in candidates winning by securing a minority of the total votes in a constituency.

However, as discussed in the Law Commission report, compulsory voting is neither desirable nor feasible in India. The solution lies in fostering enthusiasm amongst voters to exercise their right to vote through innovative campaigns, especially using social media.

For migrant workers, stricter implementation of the statutory holiday on the day of polling, coupled with an increase in transport facilities by running special buses and trains, can effectively increase participation. With the advent of newer technologies, robust and secure methods acceptable to all stakeholders for remote voting should be considered.
(Rangarajan R. is a former IAS officer and author of 'Courseware on Polity Simplified.' He currently trains at Officers IAS academy. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

The right to vote in India is a statutory right under Article 326 and the Representation of the People Act, and compulsory voting is neither a fundamental duty nor a legal duty.

While higher voter turnout shows a more representative democracy, compulsory voting is neither desirable nor feasible, and the focus should be on awareness, enthusiasm, and better access for voters.

